global dimension to its foreign policy.

As we saw in the previous chapter, President Xi Jinping started using the phrases ‘China Dream’ and ‘Great Rejuvenation of the Chinese People’ after his visit to the National Museum of China in 2012. These phrases – ‘Community of Common Destiny’, ‘China Dream’ and ‘Great Rejuvenation of the Chinese People’ – have together become the markers of a China aspiring to a global role.

As pointed out earlier, in the initial period following the global financial and economic crisis, Chinese activism was centred more on its Asian neighbourhood and pursued through its top priority of ‘peripheral diplomacy’. The concepts of Community of Common Destiny and China Dream were both explicitly linked to integrating the neighbourhood with China. For example, the Central Foreign Affairs Work Conference held in 2014 stated that it was important to ‘interpret the China Dream from the perspective of our neighbours’. In this phase, the BRI and the AIIB, headquartered in Beijing, were directed towards Asia. It is in the latter half of the decade that China began to perceive an even greater shift in the international balance of power, opening up new opportunities to expand its external profile beyond Asia.

At the 2017 conference of Chinese diplomatic envoys, Chinese President Xi Jinping referred to the dawn of a ‘new era’, marked by ‘changes unseen in a century’. [5] This latter phrase has now become a constant refrain in the speeches of Chinese leaders, Party documents and scholarly commentaries. These ‘changes unseen in a century’ have been linked to the changes in the balance of power globally. In referring to this, Xi said, ‘The international structure has become increasingly balanced and this general trend has become irreversible.’ [6] What is important to note in this formulation is not just the change in the balance of power, but that the change was ‘irreversible’. This judgement came in the wake of Trump’s victory in the US presidential elections and the steps he began to take to withdraw from various international commitments, downgrade US-led alliances like the North Atlantic Treaty Organization (NATO) and opt for unilateral moves rather than work through multilateral institutions and observe norms that